

TWICE AS NICE PM Modi and RSS chief Bhagwat at the Hedgewar Smruti Mandir in Nagpur, Mar. 30

ing all traces of the colonial mindset, honour and pride in our roots, our unity and the realisation of a sense of duty among citizens.

In his 11-year tenure so far, PM Modi has popularised many of the RSS's ideas, including taking yoga to the world, articulating the world-view of *vasudaiva kutumbakam* (world as a family) as a mainstay of foreign policy, evolved the swadeshi economic philosophy with a call for self-reliance, along with resolving key issues like the abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu and Kashmir, construction of the Ram temple in Ayodhya, pushing for the uniform civil code and, lately, accelerating the reforms for the Waqf Board.

The Vijayadashami celebrations this year will be special, for the Sangh is completing 100 years of its existence. Formed in 1925, it was modelled on the structure of the Boy's Scouts in England, with aspirations for a Hindu cultural revival. But unlike many similar outfits which sprung up around the world at the time but shrunk to the margins over the years, the RSS thrived. This is because the RSS has a unique structure, replicating some aspects of organisations like the ultranationalist Nippon Kaigi in Japan, or the ONF (All-Russian People's front) in Russia.

Yet there is no organisation that can compare to the RSS. During its 100-year celebrations, Sangh sources say, they would like to showcase some of these unique qualities, adding that they hope the state will back them on this. Today, if, at the centre, an erstwhile *pracharak* is the country's prime minister, nearly half his cabinet too has been part of the RSS or its affiliates at some point. Indeed, 12 of the Sangh's former swayamsevaks (11 from the BJP and one even from the Congress) lead governments in their respective states.

As an organisation, the Sangh and its affiliates have a presence in every aspect of Indian society. American academic, author and long-time RSS watcher Walter K. Andersen says the organisation "stands out vis-a-vis its counterparts in other parts of the world". He argues that the political victories are often credited to aggressive campaigns, mass rallies and media narratives, yet beneath the spectacle, the real build-up is shaped by quiet groundwork. This is what makes the Sangh indispensable for the BJP.

In the past year, as the assembly polls in Haryana, Maharashtra and recently in Delhi showed, RSS swayamsevaks on the ground during election time are a game-changer for the BJP. The Sangh has also benefited from the popularity of PM Modi while the BJP's political might has opened up new geographies and demographies. The Sangh's 'mass outfits', such as the Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh, the Kisan Sangh, the Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad along with the Adhivakta Parishad and the Sewa Bharati, have all seen their numbers more than double in the past decade.

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victories in the states afterwards, all is now water under the bridge. Sources in the RSS and BJP say the PM's visit was to underline how important both sides are to each other. When PM Modi talked about how the RSS's *tapasya* (penance)—with its *sangathan* (organisation) and *samarpan* (dedication) in the past 100 years—had borne fruit, he was only reiterating the message.

To the outer world, the PM himself is a prime example of the Sangh's swayamsevaks. Modi had already articulated the '*panch pran*' or the five fundamentals of 'Amrit Kaal' as the country approaches its target of 'Viksit Bharat' in 2047. At the core of the Sangh's ideology of cultural nationalism and revival as well, these include the goal of a developed India, eliminat-